

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 3
Painting the Stars ~ Imagining a Future
20 September 2026

LVF Updated 5 September 1:30pm

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML, Laude, and ..

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and ... center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Welcome this morning to First Church. Your presence enriches us and our time of worship.
As we gather, I invite you to listen now to these mystical words from the Bengali poet, Tagore.

Words of Gathering 4 Readers Needed

The ancient ones saw it this way:

In the beginning, the Holy One allowed the light,
'Let there be light,'
and from Spirit's being,
radiance emerged
that lit creation's path toward its sacred future.

The scientists see it this way:

In the beginning, from the darkness and emptiness
of nothingness,
an unaccountable explosion of radiation
expanded outward in all directions,
which now our measurements can measure.

The first disciples saw it this way:

Jesus, too, allowed the light to brighten
dark death's reign,
announcing a new creation,
brightened by justice for all.

We might look at it this way:

That same light that shone in Jesus shines now
through us,
and whether this becomes real to us – or not –
depends on whether we allow an eternal shining
to light our path
into a future that awaits
our distinctive stamp.

Let there be light. [adapt/bsanguin]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.

Hymn of Gathering** ***Creator God You Gave Us Life TALLIS' CANON

Creator God, you gave us life, your image formed within our souls,
Yet through the mist of time and space, we search for that which makes us whole.

In every flower and every tree, we see your great diversity,
Yet greater still we see your love, expressed in our humanity.

When with our hearts, our hands, our minds, we share our gifts with all the world,
Our spirits soar beyond the veil, to touch the very face of God.

Through hands that paint majestic skies, and voices chanting melody,
With words that reach beyond the page, we comprehend your mystery.

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

ML

All things are born of you, O God.
We carry within us your light and your life.

In the mystery of matter
and deep in the cells of our souls
are your longings for oneness.

The oneness of the universe
vast and vibrating with the sound of its beginning.

The oneness of the earth
greening and teaming as a single body.

The oneness of the human soul
a sacred countenance in infinite form.

As we consider the beauty

*of this earth and our life together,
grant us your longings for oneness, O God,
amidst all life's glorious multiplicities.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

Rise Up, My Love!

Eleanor Daley

Tiffany Ho, Molly Pease, Anna Caplan, Chohi Kim, *Quartet*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*
*Rise up, my Love, my fair one, and come away. For lo! The winter has passed, the rain is over
and gone. The flowers appear upon the earth, the time of the singing of birds is come.*

[... to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

Let us now join our voices in this Lord's Prayer...

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In this world of differences
we are challenged to see the sacred
in many faces and many traditions.

In this world of options,
we are challenged to remain true to what we know
of that sacredness, of ourselves, of those we love.

In this world of blessing,
we know gifts of beauty and wonder
and seek to ground them in all holiness.

May the differences we find this day
bless us with a deep and sustained
awareness of the presence of the sacred
in our oft-confusing world.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[...to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

A Reading from Psalm 1 ~ A 21st Century Exploration by Francis Macnab

There are many pathways in front of us.
We see some people take pathways that turn-out
to be destructive and unhealthy.
But our happiness and well-being depend on us
taking the pathways that keep us connected
with the best purposes
and with the best spirit.

Look carefully at the tree that flourishes beside the river -
its leaves are healthy and it bears fruit in season.
We can be like the tree.
But we can forget all that and become
like chaff blown in all directions by the wind.

God of all life has created in us a desire to be the best we can be.
When we follow that desire,
our whole being is strongly affirmed.
But when we become indifferent to that desire,
we lose our connection with the best purposes
and the best spirit. [FMacnab/fwb]

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph short transition ML center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts
for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are
online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in
the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and
hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Creating God,
what incredible diversity exists in our world –
in nature, in our bodies, in our beliefs.
We live along the invisible line
that runs between
the ‘this’ and ‘that’ of our existence,
shifting our choices,
developing our ideas,
bending to the wisdom of those
whose perspective we value.

*May we ever seek and celebrate
the truths discovered along
a line illuminated by the best of who we are,
what we think,
what we value.*

And may we hold to that line,
ever loving into the best of who we are and they may be.

*As those born into light,
yet ever seeking it...
we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

[adapt/gvosper]

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

The Lord is my Shepherd

John Rutter

Rohan Ramanan, *Oboe*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

Imagining a Future

LVF

[Christoph transition ... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

In the beginning all things were created
and God said they were good.
At our beginning, we were created of God,

known to God, and treasured by God.
In every new beginning, God is still with us –
creating, transforming, renewing –
calling us into relationship with God's Self,
with each other, and with all of creation.

We have the opportunity to respond to this miracle
by living lives of simplicity and sustainability
and creating hope – even in the midst of despair.
With our offerings this morning,
we pledge to believe that we can make a difference
as we act for justice...and the healing of the earth.

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem

Two Falling Stars

Paul John Rudoi

Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Conductor

Text: HAFIZ

*Let us be like two falling stars in the day sky. Let no one know of our sublime beauty as we hold
hands with God. And burn into a sacred existence that defies – that surpasses – every
description of ecstasy and love.*

[All turn towards altar]

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[... to lectern toward end of doxology]

*Offering Prayer

*God our Creator,
you have made us one with this earth,
to tend it and to bring forth the fruit of our labor;
may we so respect and cherish
all that has life from you,
that we will continually share
all that we are and all that we have,
to bring forth your dream for our world.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML & LVF

Words of Blessing

LVF

May the Holy One,
who never ceases to practice
the art of creating
keep us ever
at the edge of our skills,
our habits,
our vision,
that we may never
grow so content
in our creating
that we miss the God
who is ever about
to do a new thing.
[janrichardson]

Choral Response

As One Sky

Paul John Rudoi
Text: Kabir

*Day and night, the chorus of music fills the heavens:
The light of the sun, the moon, and the stars shines bright. The melody of love swells forth.*

***Hymn for the Journey**

God Binds Us with a Mighty Cord

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music